

Is Hinduism More of a Culture Than a Religion?

A Comparison with India, China, and Indonesia

Is Hinduism More of a Culture Than a Religion?

A Comparison with India, China, and Indonesia



Is Hinduism a Religion or a Civilisational Culture?

The Core Question

Is Hinduism truly a "religion" in the narrow, Western sense—defined by a single book, a single prophet, and a unified creed? Or is it something different? We propose that it is something far more expansive: a **Civilisational Culture**.

Our Approach

To answer this, we must look beyond simple theology and examine sociology and history. This presentation will explore three distinct models:

- **India:** How Hinduism functions as a comprehensive "way of life."
- **China:** How tradition is managed by the state as "cultural heritage."
- **Indonesia:** How Hindu traditions survive as a "cultural aesthetic" in a Muslim-majority society.



Background & Theory

The Colonial Invention of "Religion"

Scholars argue that treating "religion" as something distinct from "culture" or "philosophy" is largely a colonial construct, not an indigenous one.

1. The Administrative Necessity

The Challenge: As argued by researcher Shyam Ranganathan, the British colonial administration encountered a vast, complex web of debating traditions in the Indian subcontinent.

The Solution: To make this manageable, they coined the term "Hinduism" as a catch-all category. It was used to classify everything indigenous that was not Islam.

2. The Pre-Colonial Reality: Dharma

Before this colonial classification, South Asian traditions were not defined by a unified belief system, but by **Dharma**.

What is Dharma? It functioned as a continuous debate on moral philosophy and the "right way of living."

The Difference: Unlike a "religion" which demands conformity to a creed, Dharma encouraged philosophical exploration.

The Crucial Distinction

Understanding this history is vital for our analysis. We are not just comparing religions; we are comparing how different civilizations navigate their past in the modern world.

Why We Are Studying This

The Macro Significance

1

Intellectual Accuracy: Correcting the Lens

The Shift: We study this to move our analytical framework from Theology (study of gods) to Civilisation (study of societies).

Why: As we will see in the next slide, using a Western lens to view Asian traditions creates a distortion. Correcting this allows us to understand the actual lived reality of 1 billion people rather than a theoretical construct.

2

Strategic Relevance: The Mechanics of the "Asian Century"

The Context: We are entering an era where culture is being weaponized and monetized.

Why: By analyzing the cases of India and China later in this presentation, we will learn how modern states are using ancient heritage as a form of "Soft Power" to redefine international diplomacy.

3

Social Utility: A Blueprint for Pluralism

The Goal: In a polarized world, we need practical examples of how different faiths can coexist.

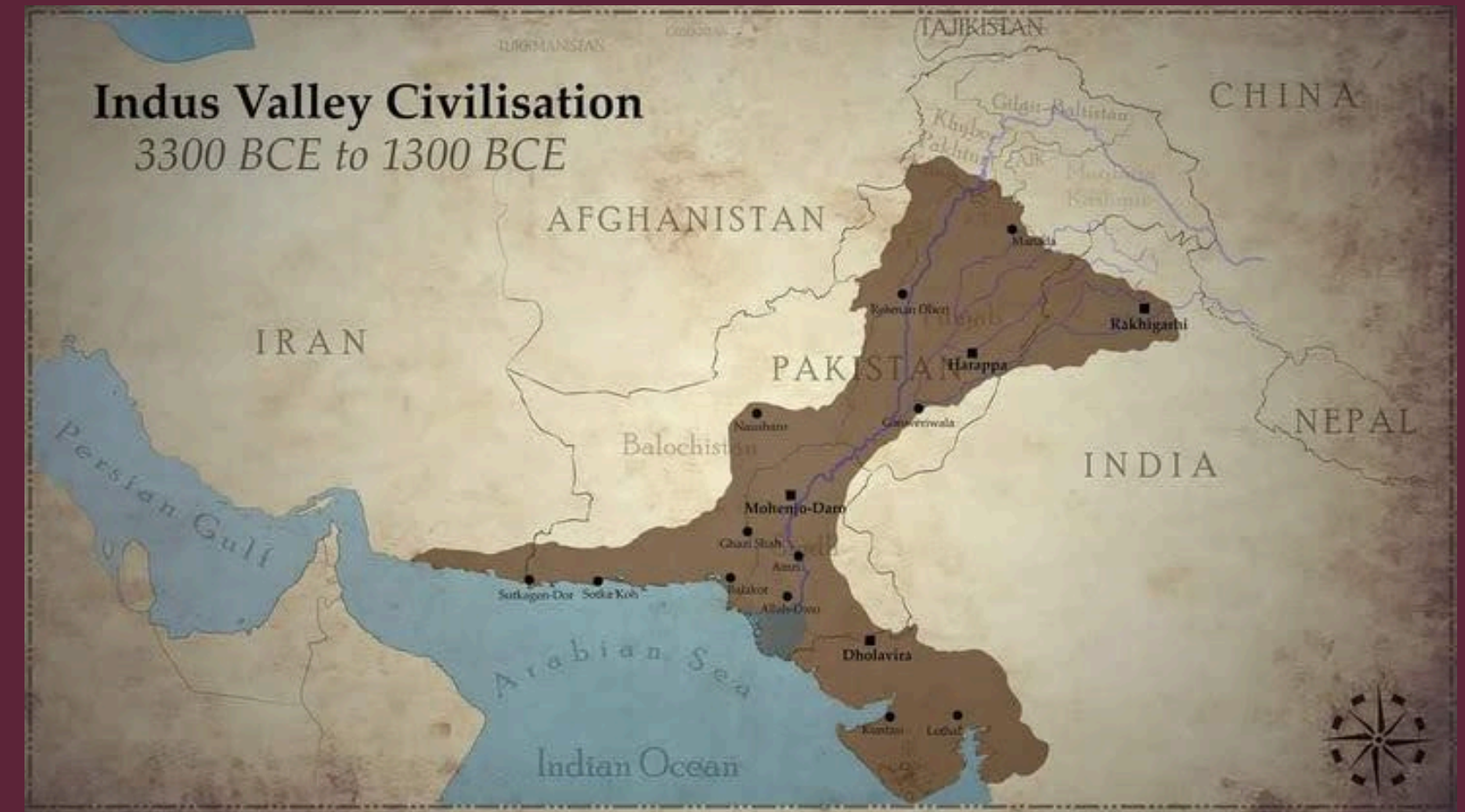
Why: This study highlights a unique model (the "Indic Belt") where cultural identity is successfully separated from religious dogma, offering a rare blueprint for modern multiculturalism.

India: The Civilisational Cradle

1. Origin of the Name: "From Sindhu to Hindu"

Geographic, Not Religious: The word "Hindu" comes from the river Sindhu (Indus).

The History: Persians and Greeks used this term to describe the people living beyond the river, not a specific religious group. It was originally a marker of location and culture.



Tethered to the Land: Today, Hinduism has about 1 billion followers, and notably, **94% of them live in India.**

2. Geography as Destiny

A Distinct Civilization: Unlike Christianity or Islam, which are "portable" and trans-national, Hinduism's sacred geography (its holy rivers, mountains, and shrines) is almost entirely located within the Indian subcontinent. This reinforces that it is a distinct civilization tied to a specific land.

The Philosophical Distinction

1

Dharma vs. Religion

A Tradition of Debate: To understand Hinduism, we must look before British colonization. It was not defined by shared beliefs, but by shared questions.

The Concept of Dharma: Instead of a rigid creed, the tradition focused on Dharma—a continuous philosophical debate about "the right way of living" and "the good."

2

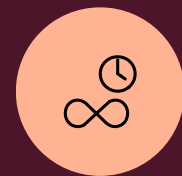
Indigenous Secularism (Free Thought)

A Broad Umbrella: Historically, this tradition was a form of "indigenous secularism." It was open enough to include:

- Theists (Devotees/Bhakti)
- Atheists (Materialists/Charvaka)

The Colonial "Box": It was the British colonial administration that took this vibrant culture of debate and flattened it into a single religious category called "Hinduism" to make it easier to manage.

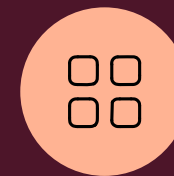
The Assimilative Nature of Sanatan Dharma



1. The Eternal Way

Sanatan Dharma: This is the indigenous name for the faith, meaning "Eternal Order." It implies universal duties rather than a sectarian church.

No Single Founder: Unlike most religions, Hinduism has no single founder and no start date. It is a massive compilation of traditions that have evolved over 4,000 years.



2. Absorption over Conquest

The "Sponge" Effect: Hinduism is confident enough to absorb new ideas rather than conquer them.

Integration: Historically, it did not destroy local tribal deities (like Naga cults). Instead, it integrated them into the main pantheon. Even the Buddha came to be revered by many as an avatar of Vishnu.

Conclusion: This proves Hinduism functions as a flexible cultural ecosystem that adapts to the times, rather than a rigid doctrine that demands everyone be the same.

India: The Modern Civilisational State

01

From Religion to Statecraft

The Shift: India is moving beyond just being a "Nation-State." It now projects itself as a "Civilisational State."

What this means: Ancient traditions are not just for personal worship anymore. They are used as tools for international diplomacy and "Soft Power."

02

Global Recognition

UNESCO: India successfully lobbied to have Yoga and the Kumbh Mela recognized as global "Intangible Cultural Heritage."

Project Mausam: The government launched this project to revive ancient maritime routes in the Indian Ocean. It counters China's influence by connecting countries through shared history rather than just trade.

China: Tradition as Cultural Heritage

1. Managing the Sacred

Different Approach: While India treats tradition as a living civilization, China manages it as a resource.

The Context: After suppressing religion during the Cultural Revolution, the state now allows it—but regulates it strictly by rebranding "folk beliefs" as culture.

2. The Strategy: "Heritagisation"

What is it? This is the process of turning a religious practice into a tourism product.

How it works: Authorities label local festivals as "Intangible Cultural Heritage." This strips away the "superstitious" or spiritual parts and keeps the colorful, cultural parts.

Example: The worship of the Sea Goddess Mazu was turned from a religious cult into a symbol of national culture and a tourist attraction.

Indonesia: The Indic Belt

1. A Shared Heritage

The Paradox: Indonesia is a Muslim-majority nation, yet it retains deep connections to Hindu traditions. This region is known as the "Indic Belt."

High Culture: Here, Hinduism functions as "culture" rather than "theology."

2. Art as Preservation

The Epics: The Indian stories of Ramayana and Mahabharata are not read as holy scriptures here; they are performed as national art.

Living Arts: These stories are the foundation of Wayang (shadow puppetry) and classical dance.

Economic Value: The connection is so strong that Indonesia's woodcraft industry (featuring these Hindu design) generated over **\$129 million** in exports in 2014.

Indonesia: Cultural Persistence & Political Adaptation

1 Deep Linguistic Roots

Language of God: Even the language used for Muslim monotheism has Hindu roots.

The Connection: The Indonesian philosophy Pancasila refers to God as *Tuhan yang Maha Esa*. The word "Esa" (One) comes from the Sanskrit word "Ishvara" (Lord/God).

2 The Balinese Exception

Adapting to survive: Bali is the only Hindu-majority island.

The Reinvention: Indonesian law requires belief in "One Supreme God." To fit in, Balinese Hindus emphasized a supreme deity called **Acintya**.

The Lesson: This shows how political laws can force a religion to redefine itself.



Comparative Synthesis

The Civilisational Spectrum Connecting the Three Nations

These are not three random examples. Together, they form a spectrum that proves our thesis.

India: The Baseline ("The Living Civilization")

Here, religion and politics are mixed. Ancient rituals coexist with the modern state. The civilization was never fully broken.

Indonesia: The Proof ("The Aesthetic Civilization")

The strongest evidence. Indonesia kept the culture (Art, Values, Epics) but changed the theology (to Islam). This proves that Hindu traditions are durable cultural assets that can survive even without the religious belief.

China: The Control ("The Heritagized Civilization")

China acts as a foil. It actively separates culture from belief. It validates that these traditions are valuable for national identity, even when secularized.

Conclusion:

Hinduism acts as a **Civilisational Matrix**, not a rigid creed.

The Final Verdict

Is Hinduism a Religion or a Culture?

The Evidence Points to Culture:

- **In India:** It is Sanatan Dharma—an eternal way of life that includes atheists and theists.
- **In Indonesia:** It survives as the classical aesthetic of the nation.
- **In China:** It is managed as heritage and history.

Closing Thought

Viewing Hinduism narrowly as a "religion" obscures the truth. It is a complex, adaptive **Civilisational System** that has shaped the social and artistic fabric of Asia for 4,000 years.

References

Academic Sources

- Jha, Gautam Kumar. (2021). "Indic Elements in Indonesian Arts and Literature." *Heritage of Nusantara*.
- Rakshit, Srija. (2023). "Hinduism - A Religion or Way of Life?" *IJCSPUB*.
- Ranganathan, Shyam. (2022). "Hinduism, Belief and the Colonial Invention of Religion." *Religions*.
- Singh, Rani & Winter, Tim. (2023). "From Hinduism to Hindutva: Civilizational Internationalism and UNESCO." *International Affairs*.

Additional Resources

- UNESCO. (2003). *Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage*.
- Project Mausam. Ministry of Culture, Government of India.